

DENMARK

The erstwhile seat of Viking raiders, Denmark has evolved into a modern, prosperous nation with an advanced broadband infrastructure and one of the highest levels of broadband penetration in Europe.

Denmark replaced Sweden as the information champion in the IDC Information Society Index (ISI) 2004. It leads in the telecom variable—notably wireless subscribers, high user penetration and mobile Internet users. Almost 69 per cent of the Danish population accesses the Internet, with 84 per cent connecting from



Capital: Copenhagen
Population (millions): 5.4
Area: 43,093 sq km
Internet Penetration: 68.7 % (Mar 05)

home, 22 per cent of households using broadband while the total mobile subscriber penetration in Denmark reached 60 per cent.

Denmark also ranked No. 1 in the EIU's 2005 e-readiness rankings, and was proclaimed to be the best place in the world to conduct business over the next five years. The government has promised to boost spending on R&D, and facilitate the creation of knowledge industry.

According to the Computer Industry Almanac, Denmark is among the leading countries in computer and Internet penetration—as of 2004, there were 682 surfers per 1,000 Denmark residents, compared to 649 in Australia; 641 in Canada; 611 in Japan; 570 in the UK; and 628 in the US.

Denmark has it all—highly developed infrastructure and institutions, a skilled labour force, low inflation rates, political and economic stability, and an internationally plugged financial sector.

CANADA

Canada has one of the highest rates of Internet usage and broadband adoption in the world. It ranked fifth on IDC's Information Society Index (2004). Residential broadband access enjoyed continued growth in 2004 as the increase in dial-up accounts slowed.

Broadband deployment continues to progress under active government encouragement, with 85 per cent of Canadians now living in communities served by high-speed Internet access.

The 2004/2005 Telecoms, Mobile and Broadband in Canada Report by BuddeComm indicates that almost 43 per cent of Canadians use a wireless device. Canadians are heavy Web users, with 90 per cent using e-mail weekly. Anti-spam/virus software company, Sophos, ranked Canada as the fourth highest spamming nation in November 2004 with 5.7 per cent of all spam in the world originating from Canada.

The Canadian Government launched an anti-spam action plan in 2004. The Canadian Internet Registration Authority operates the dot-ca Internet country code Top Level Domain—there are more than 530,000 .ca domain names.



Capital: Ottawa
Population (millions): 32.5
Area: 9,976,137 sq km
Internet penetration: 63.8 % (Dec 03)

SWEDEN

Another Scandinavian nation, Sweden has one of the world's highest life expectancies and one of the lowest birth rates. It's the most tech-savvy country in Europe according to a 2005 report by Jupiter Research, a US market analysis firm. Sweden was ranked as the third most e-ready nation by EIU (2005).

The EIU named Sweden as best-in-class in key areas of connectivity—mobile penetration and Internet use, and a standard setter in e-government implementation. Sweden ranked second in the Information Society Index by IDC in 2004—with highest penetration of Internet access, highest usage of mobile phones, and a very high level of Internet and computer skills among business managers. For instance, it has the highest business penetration rates for Microsoft Windows and Apple OS.

The gadget loving populace doubles as an advanced testing ground for a range of mobile commerce applications—even the Bluetooth technology was invented in Sweden. The country's WCDMA (Wideband Code Division Multiple Access) 3G mobile infrastructure covers over 70 percent of the population, state wireless consultants Northstream.

Incidentally, Sweden is the only country in the world to have more mobile phones than inhabitants—thanks to lower calling costs than any other European nation!



Capital: Stockholm
Population (millions): 9.04
Area: 449,965 sq km
Internet penetration: 73.6 % (Feb 05)

THE UNITED STATES OF AMERICA

The US ranked third on the Information Society Index by IDC (2004), and ranked second on e-readiness (EIU 2005). This land of silicon chip innovators and manufacturers scored highest for PCs per household and software spending, steadfast in its position as the world's largest consumer of computer products and services. The US also ranked higher because of secure Internet server penetration, overall spending on IT and growth in broadband adoption.

The US remains the world's leading broadband user with nearly 31.7 million lines in the third quarter of 2004. The number of broadband users increased 36 per cent in 2004, accounting for 55 per cent of the total at-home users by the end of 2004, according to a survey by Nielsen/NetRatings.

In fact, nearly three out of four US households with a phone line have access to the Internet, states the February 2004 Nielsen/NetRatings survey.

According to Sophos, the US continues to lead the world in originating spam attacks; accounting for over two out of every five (42.1 per cent) spam e-mails sent throughout the world.

According to research group Point Topic, the total number of US DSL (digital subscriber line) subscribers is growing, but still lags behind the country's 19 million-plus cable modem subscribers.

In July 2004, residential broadband connections in the country overtook the use of slower, dial-up connections for the first time. Almost one-third of the wireless services budget in the US is now dedicated to data. The vast majority (91 per cent) of US firms use wireless data. ☒



Capital: Washington D.C.
Population (million): 296
Area: 9,629,047 sq km
Internet penetration: 67.8% (Feb 05)

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